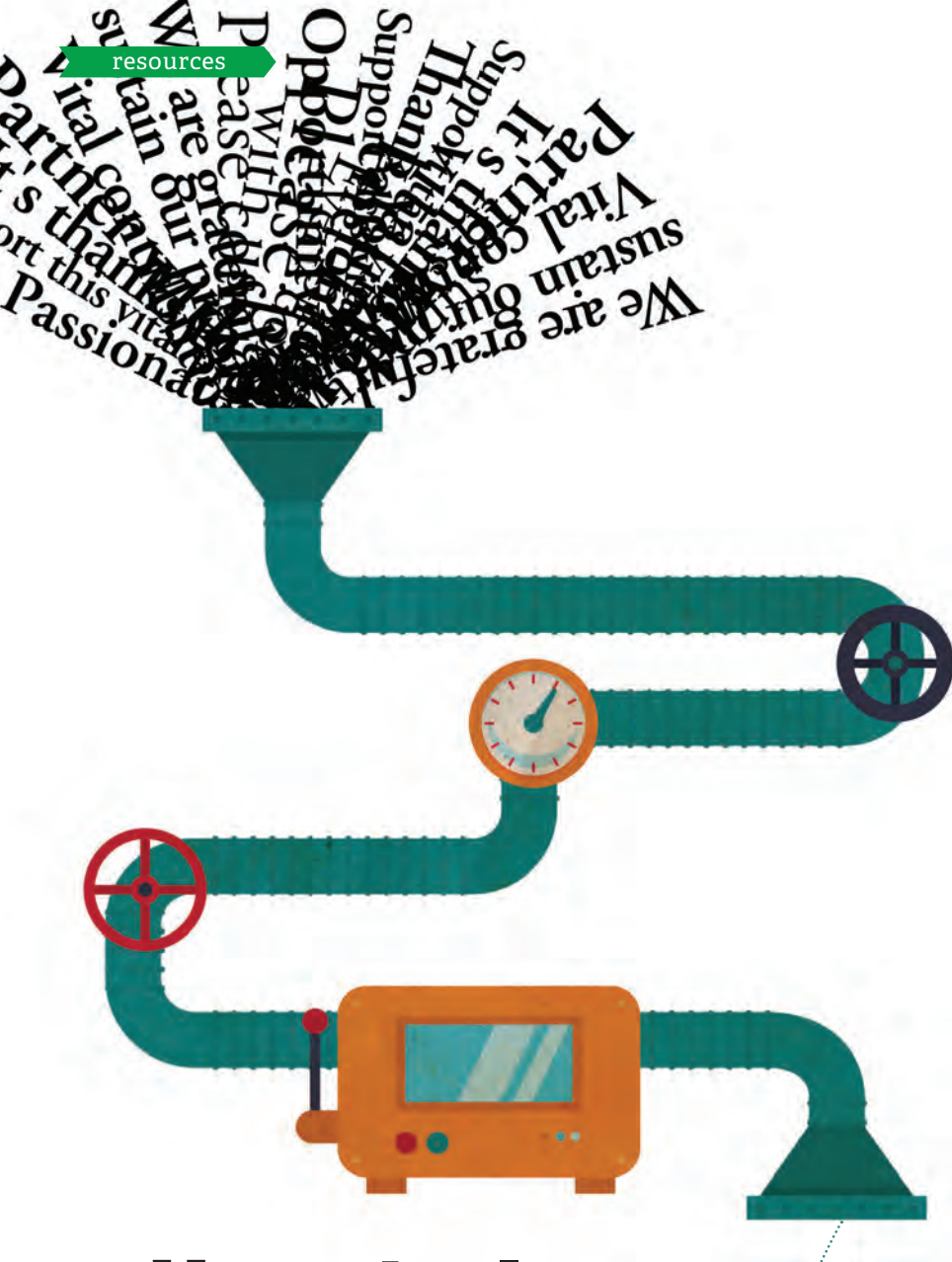




How to Increase the Effectiveness of Your Emails



How can I get my emails to stand out from the hubbub? How can I get people to open my emails and actually pay attention?" Here are some great tips on the ins and outs of effective emailing.

Is email still relevant today?

Irrespective of the dizzying variety of social media mediums in today's market, emails still carry weight. Social media and email serve different, and complementary, purposes.

While social media is great at keeping your community engaged with your daily activities, email is unparalleled as a solid "push" medium. It offers the ability to target a person directly in his inbox, simultaneously providing fully developed content. A good marketing strategy will use both tools to maximize its toolbox power.

Before you start

KNOW YOUR GOAL

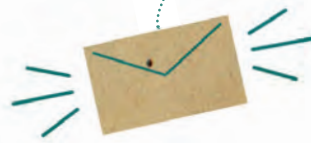
Even before you hit compose, identify what you want the email to accomplish. For your reader to have a fighting chance at understanding your goal, you need to have it clear within yourself from the get-go.

KNOW YOUR AUDIENCE

Teens enjoy fun and excitement, while the middle-aged appreciate meaning and inspiration. Try to write the way your readership thinks.

The subject line

Think of the subject as your hook—the very first point of contact has to be powerful and hard-hitting. Additionally, the



subject line should inform the recipients—even those who don’t open the email—a general picture of what the email is promoting.

IN THAT VEIN:

- ➔ Pique your readers’ curiosity so they stop and take a second look. For example, instead of “Class on Genesis,” use “Discover how 5,000-year-old wisdom can revamp your relationships.”
- ➔ Keep it short—less than 50 characters. Longer will be ignored.
- ➔ Don’t be laid back. Use words such as “revamp,” “breath-taking,” or “amazing.”
- ➔ Try writing in first or second person. For example, use “Want to meet Monday?” instead of “Monday discussion group.” Use the preheader (see below) to spell out more details (e.g. “Join the Monday night discussion group at Chabad”).

PREHEADERS

If you take a look at your inbox, you’ll notice a couple of words right after the subject line. Email providers pull the first words of text from your email to provide a preview of what the email is about. That’s the “preheader.”

Make sure the first line in your email is inspiring and catchy and continues the subject line theme. Use it as a second chance to draw people in. (On the techy side, there are ways to create a preheader just for the inbox that won’t show up in your actual email.)

Note: emails containing only images can run into an issue here, since normally their first words are “To view in your browser, click here”—not quite the most inspiring lines in the book. Deal with this by putting a catchy line of text above the image.

“A marketing email should take no more than 30 seconds to read, a newsletter—two to three minutes. Keep in mind the three “shorts”: short words, short sentences, and short paragraphs.”



Getting Your Email Point Across: The Email Body

SAY “HI!”

Most emails should start off with a brief greeting before getting to the topic at hand (although sometimes your email appeal can be heightened by skipping this step). Follow that with a paragraph or two about the subject—staying to the point and on topic—and then sign off.

REMEMBER: SHORT IS SWEET

An email is not a book. A marketing email should take no more than 30 seconds to read, a newsletter—two to three minutes. Keep in mind the three “shorts”: short words, short sentences, and short paragraphs.

1. BREAK UP THOSE SENTENCES.

Keep sentences short. If you’re on the fence about whether to divide the sentence, break it. It will make your email so much more interesting and readable.

2. SOME SIMPLE ENGLISH, PLEASE.

Use words people use—the simpler the better. This doesn’t mean to never use some well-heeled English, but do strike a balance between simple and elegant.

1. SO WHERE WAS I?

Give the guy in a rush a break and make your emails scannable. Bold key words, use bullet points, and break down paragraphs. It’ll make things easier and so much quicker.

GET PERSONAL

How inclined are you to read emails from family and friends? How about an email from a random company solely interested in your business?

Personal is relevant. Treat your emails as a personal conversation in writing from start to finish.

Personalization is not just about using the recipient’s name, but about the language and feeling. Imagine you are writing to an acquaintance of yours and then adapt that letter for the wider public.

In individual emails, you can add a note, such as “How was your trip?” or “I

saw your piece that was published in the *Winterville Daily Times* on the meaning of life—it was great!” (This can work for a stranger, too.)

In mass emails, make the tone as conversational as you can. And use language that talks about the person doing the action, not as if the action happened on its own. For example, use “We will update you” instead of “You will be updated.” This helps remind the reader that there is a real person on the other end, not an anonymous computer program.

STAY DIGNIFIED

Though it’s important to be relatable, you don’t want to come across as overly conversational, depending on the context. Keep your dignity about you and be polite.

LIVEN IT UP

Add vivid details, utilize metaphors, and employ power words, such as “amazing,” “blissful,” “courage,” “daring,” “jaw-dropping,” “uplifting,” “bonanza,” and “bargain.” This will turn the email from a dry piece of text into a living, breathing image.

LET YOUR PERSONALITY SHINE THROUGH

Let your passion seep into your emails; it will give them a whole new vigor. One way to do this is by typing your email as quickly as you can. Though you’ll edit it afterward, the email will contain your raw feelings.

KEEP YOUR EMOTIONS POSITIVE

A tricky part of emailing is the emotional context, since email has no body language and words will often seem harsher than the reality. Avoid words that imply negativity, such as “angry,” “unacceptable,” “unprofessional,” and “disrespectful.” If you can’t calm down, wait until later to write the email. As a general rule, never write what you wouldn’t say in person.

FOCUS ON THE RECIPIENT

Evaluate: is there more use of the word “we” or “you”? When advertising a product or program, list the the benefits the user or attendee will gain, instead of your accomplishments or the features.

If you’re emailing about a JLI class, focus on the shift in perspective the person will attain, using the vastness of the source material and fascinating audiovisuals, etc., as the supplementary details.

PUNCTUATE PRUDENTLY

Aside from keeping to basic grammar, here are some points to watch out for:

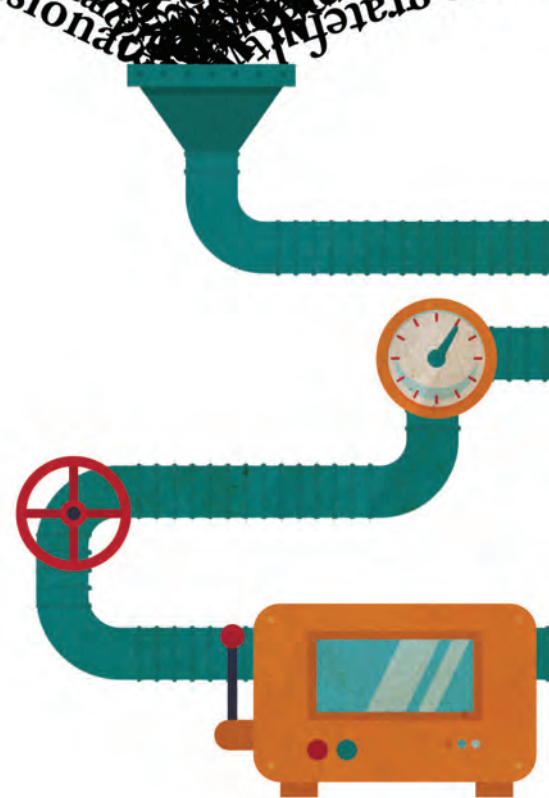
- ➔ Avoid overuse of exclamation marks and emoticons. Although they sometimes provide that extra touch or give the right emphasis, overuse makes the text more worthy of a class WhatsApp group.
- ➔ Avoid using FULLY CAPITALIZED words, whether in the subject line or email body. It gives off a very unpolished vibe.

TIME TO CUT TO THE CHASE

After explaining where you’re coming from spell out what the reader’s next step should be and how he or she is to go about doing so via a call to action. Calls to action don’t always end with the reader signing up for your offer. They are simply about encouraging the next step in the reader’s engagement. Examples include “Please reply to let me know...,” “Watch the trailer [here](#),” “Kindly take a moment now to mark your calendar,” and “Please post this link to your social media outlets.”

A couple of call-to-action pointers:

- ➔ Calls to action should be clear and easy, with little effort on the part of your reader. As much as possible should be doable from within the email itself or the very



“
As a general rule, never write what you wouldn’t say in person.
”

first page the link takes him to.

- ➔ Have the same call to action presented in a variety of forms throughout the email. But avoid cluttering by going overboard.

OFFER INCENTIVES

Every shliach knows about the free kiddush trick to get people to shul. With the correct incentive, this concept will work for any demographic. Think of what your crowd enjoys and base your incentive off of that. Incentives for some crowds are most effective as part of a larger package, while others are exciting on their own.

When providing an incentive, communicate a sense of urgency: “Be from the first 100 to register and get half price!” or “Three days left!” Similar to a 24-hour funding campaign, the sense of urgency gets things moving.

OFFER A WAY OUT

Though it may seem counterintuitive, offering a way out (and, in mass emails, the option to unsubscribe) shows the recipient that you respect his independence and judgement and will gain you trust.

DOUBLE-CHECK, TRIPLE-CHECK, AND DOUBLE-CHECK AGAIN.

Before hitting “Send,” read your email one more time. Then just once more. If it’s really important, sleep on it and reread it in the morning before hitting “Send.” Check the address, the subject and the email body. You’ll be shocked at the number of embarrassing mistakes that will have become glaringly obvious. 📧

SAMPLE EMAIL

